Testimony in Indian Philosophy

One of the distinguishing features of Indian philosophy is that almost all the orthodox schools, in addition to other commonly accepted instruments of knowledge like perception and inference, believe in testimony*, i.e., verbal or written authority *(śabda)* as one of the valid means of knowledge *(pramāṇas)*. It is sometimes said that it is here that Indian philosophy differs most prominently from Western philosophy. Indian philosophy not only recognizes testimony among its sources of knowledge, but sometimes even accords it a higher place of importance, inasmuch as by authority alone are certain facts supposed to be known which are not capable of being revealed by other sources of knowledge. Sometimes, again, perception, inference, etc., are in the last analysis made dependent on agreement with authority. Modern Western philosophy, on the contrary, is founded upon a revolt against authority. Frequently, the history of Western philosophy impresses upon the reader the fact that, while the medieval period is characterized by belief in the authoritative character of revelation, the history of ancient and modern philosophy constitutes eras of reason and free thought. Modern philosophy is supposed to have banished the appeal to testimony, divine or secular, from rational inquiry. Authority may find recognition in religion, but has no place in philosophical and logical investigation, which recognizes only two sources of valid knowledge, i.e., the immediate source of sense perception and the mediate source of inferential reasoning.

In Western philosophy, therefore, there is supposed to be a kind of antithesis between authority and reason. One may choose to put

*The terms "testimony" and "authority" have both been used in this paper to stand for the original Sanskrit term *"śabda,"* which means "the word of a reliable person." Actually, in Indian philosophy, there is no difference in the meaning of the two words, but in view of the difference in modern usage, care has been taken to use here one or the other according to what has appeared more appropriate in the given context.